

SNZ #CLASSIFIEDS

"A true artist understands that his
creation is not in service of him,
but he is in service of his creation."

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with 12 words

1732 sats \ 75 comments \
[@DarthCoin](#) 21 Oct bitcoin



40sats. to 1-



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SNZ #CLASSIFIEDS

stacker news
weekly zine

in this issue

"Why does
anyone want
bitcoin anyway?"

Issue 30

Oct 18 - Oct 24
920493 \$110542

stacker news zine is a weekly publication of the best facts and fictions from your favorite pay-2-post bitcoin-only forum

you could be featured here by going to stacker.news and dropping your knowledge in tech or your libertarian opinion, reporting the state of things in your neck of the woods, or anything you can think of!

made by [@plebpoet](#)
with [@k00b](#) who
was around



T O P B O O S T

Great Script Restoration Project Q&A with Rusty Russell and Julian Moik



1665 sats \ 10k boost \ 2 comments \ [@lightcoin](#) 20 Oct bitcoin
zaps forwarded to [@Rusty](#) (100%)

Note from the Editor

The leaves are changing! The air is crispening! The stackers are stacking!

I collected leaves and other small things off the streets to show the signs of fall happening, which is my favorite time of the year. I would bet that it's yours, too. No, I don't know that for sure, but since fall is the best season, you know, harvest and the prosperity it brings - I think my bet is a safe one.

But you tell me, what *is* your favorite season? Do you notice them as they pass? Or do you keep your head in a screen?



T O P B O O S T

I built a website that organizes bitcoin tutorial videos from across youtube



9586 sats \ 10k boost \ 18 comments \ [@ihatevake](#) 23 Oct bitcoin

I don't think you understand how credit cards "work"



1603 sats \ 34 comments \ @DarthCoin 18 Oct bitcoin

And here is another explosive "blast from the past" post from Mircea Popescu's blog - Trilema. I am re-posting it here, for posterity, in case his Trilema blog get nuked.



[Source link here](#) - 18 Oct 2016

I think this post is targeting all those that still use such fiat cards and especially the ones so called "bitcoin / crypto debit cards".

People in the habit of using their brain often laugh at poorly specified, horrendously designed, shodily implemented altcoins, and for good reason - there's apparently no shortage of these end products of an ambitious process which included no thinking whatsoever. Credit cards are perhaps the most egregious example of them all.

According to the whitepaper, a credit card is a paper wallet which may contain one single address. The address is composed of 16 numeric digits, which are usually formatted with three dashes, and it is secured by a "secret" private key which is... four digits long. To further securitize this secure security, a three digit super-key is printed on the back of the paper wallet in question, and that's it, you're good to go!

How is this abomination to be used in practice ? Oh, that's simple - just like its users. For instance you can walk up to a machine, stick your paper wallet into it, and then type the private key. Yeah, that's right, you type your private key into a big box you don't own, nor control in any way, and can't inspect. What protects you from the owner of the machine selectively scamming ? A shoddy, slow, bug ridden, unauditable, ad-hoc reimplementaion of the common WoT.iv And if the operator decides to charge your card twice, or fifty billiard times, the best you can do is call an Indian. They'll be thrilled to listen and eagerly try to help! Have you tried rebooting your credit card wallet sir ?



Credit Card Altcoin user completing almost last and final KYC verification step

What protects you from someone spying on you while you put your private key in ? Nothing. This actually happens all the time, it's called "credit card fraud" - because evidently making the world's worst altcoin and pushing it on naive people is no kind of fraud. Fraud is only when the wind blows over a rotten reed, not when the reed was rotten in the first place!

But suppose you don't want to do that. What else can this altcoin be used for ? Why, you could pay for your meal! Like, walk into an eatery, hand over your paper wallet to an overworked, underpaid, sub-minimum wage worker who depends on tips to survive and works such impossible hours in such miserable conditions he's about 17 times more likely to abuse psychoactive substances than the general population. Then you tell them your private key. The private key to your only public address which holds all your funds. What prevents them from making a copy ? Nothing whatsoever, this also happens all the time (credit card fraud, remember). What prevents the eatery from double charging ? The WoT which they don't call a WoT, nor does it really work. . .



. . . The only thing this idiocy has going for it is that it's widely used. This happens to also be the only thing this idiocy has going against it - as the moral obligation of every thinking man to "defraud" this nonsense (in the sense of separating the idiots involved from any sort of usable

contents they may be carrying) becomes ever more obvious to the thinking men in question, the credit card altcoin will cry foul, be forked and the the forks forked, but eventually wither and die. Because when it comes to money, there can only be one.



What Tabconf7 taught me about Stacker News



6669 sats \ 23 comments \ @Scoresby 18 Oct events

I am not a conference enjoyoor

I have been to two other Bitcoin conferences in the past. In 2024, I attended Bitcoin++ in Austin because @niftynei graciously asked if I wanted to sell my posters there, and I went to Bitcoin 2025 in Las Vegas to meet up with someone I was working with.

They were wildly different experiences. Bitcoin++ was wonderful: first time I met @ek, I got to hang out with @plebpoet and a few other stackers, and my kids came along. Bitcoin 2025 was unpleasant: really huge, felt like a casino (perhaps because it was located in one), hard to meet people.

Tabconf is like a big friendly meetup

Never having been to Tabconf before, I was very pleasantly surprised! The conference took place in a small exhibition hall. There was one large room with lots of tables where people could hang out, and then two rooms for talks.

Tabconf7 had a very chill vibe. The main room with the tables usually had a good number of people milling about -- so much so that I was only reminded about the various talks next door by the applause when they ended. It never felt lonely. It certainly didn't feel like people were there trying to sell anything.

The Bitcoiners I met impressed me with their curiosity, friendliness, and thoughtfulness. I learned a lot about Bitcoin and met people who were interested in doing the same. There wasn't really any discussion of Michael Saylor, the ETFs, or even the Knots v Core thing...or most of the other things that seem such a big part of Bitcoin discourse on X and reddit. Turns out the Bitcoiners in real life are concerned with learning about Bitcoin and trying to use it.

Stacker News in Real Life

@BlokchainB's idea to have a place for Stackers to meet up in real life (#1220292) was brilliant.

It may seem obvious, but before this last week, I would have said meeting up in real life isn't that important: I like meetups, but I have always assumed conferences were a kind of frivolous extra.

But hanging out with stackers at Tabconf was one of the highlights of this whole year. A stacker's presence on SN is like a little window into who they are, but meeting a stacker in person is like walking up to their house and seeing where the window fits in the whole abode.

Bitcoin already selects for a unique group of people. Lightning users are a subset, and perhaps a concentrated version of this and stackers are subset of that -- while this does mean there isn't stackers aren't a huge group of people, it also means if you are a stacker you are pretty likely to have A LOT in common with any other stacker. It makes it easy to start a friendship.

I am very thankful to @BlokchainB, @k00b, and all the stackers who showed up! Stackers are very cool people and I'm grateful to be able to count a number of them as my friends. I'm also pretty impressed with @tidwell -- that's one heck of a great conference you put on! Definitely plan on coming back next year.

What stands in the way of new stackers

I'd say 60% of the people had heard of Stacker News, but most of those had either stopped using their account or never created one in the first place. It's also possible there's a little bias in this because nobody likes to say "I've never heard of this thing."

In my efforts to onboard new users, I ran in to a new dynamic that I hadn't previously considered: there were a number of very serious and knowledgeable bitcoiners who were not lightning users. They don't have a problem with lightning, but just hadn't had an occasion to set up a node or use a lightning wallet.

In talking through the easiest way for them to onboard to SN, I often ended up proposing custodial solutions like CoinOS or ecash wallets like Minibits. It was pointed out to me on several occasions that this wasn't good.

c o n t i n u e d

Of course, I could have suggested they set up a node and open channels, but this is not the sort of thing one does in five minutes while chatting with each other. I suspect that some very interesting Bitcoiners who would enjoy SN are still being kept away by the setup cost of lightning (or by the icky feeling they get from custody). I don't think this is a problem SN needs to solve, it is inherent to lightning -- but it is a real obstacle to a number of people who would have otherwise been ideal stackers.

How I pitched SN to Bitcoiners at the conference

I have been completely convinced by @DarthCoin that pay to post is the major innovation of SN. But despite my commitment to the idea, I found it usually came second or third in my pitch to the people who came by our table.

Most often my pitch was something like: "It's a forum like reddit or hacker news but everything is done with sats -- you pay to post, you pay to like, you earn sats when people like what you write."

Sometimes I would say things like "It is one of the places on the internet where you are most likely to be zapped."

In most cases I felt like my pitch wasn't very compelling. I'm not sure if I was failing to articulate the problem SN solves or if I was getting bogged down too much in the details ("No mods...well, actually there are mods, but only on some territories...territories are like sub-reddits or topic-based little mini forums" or "you have to use lightning to use SN, unless you don't want to earn sats -- then you can just get cowboy credits, which are like points that you can buy with sats, but you can't withdraw them, but mostly people use sats and that's why you need to connect a wallet -- you can connect lots of different lightning wallets, but not Phoenix, well you can connect Phoenixd..."). I really need to refine my pitch.

Conclusion: I highly recommend attending smaller, more technical Bitcoin conferences (even if you are not technical). Meeting Stackers in real life makes using SN even better.

O T H E R G R E A T P O S T S



Had a little play
on ShockWallet by
Justin Shocknet

3874 sats \ 9 comments \

@nelom 21 Oct lightning



My demo from PlebLab
Mexico: ShockWallet and
Lightning.Pub featuring CLINK

4117 sats \ 29 comments \

@justin_shocknet 19 Oct lightning



I bought my first SNZ

3242 sats \ 7 comments \ @SatAttack

22 Oct bitcoin



Research in Public #06: Unprofitable users exit more when btc price high

3120 sats \ 11 comments \ @SimpleStacker 20 Oct econ



06.

Introduction

In #1243188 I suggested to @k00b that we engage in a research project using SN data. The idea would be to use this data to study: A) how micropayments with real money affects internet discourse; and B) barriers to the adoption of self-custody. I also promised @Undisciplined that I'd carry out the research in public, since many people might not know what economics research looks like, and may be curious as to how the process plays out. You can follow all of the updates [here](#).



05.

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04.

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03.

Recap thus far

So far, I've demonstrated that users are indeed responsive to posting fees:



02.

The quantity of posts goes down when territory posting costs go up (#1253062)



01.

The quality of posts, as measured by zaps and comments in the first 48 hours, goes up when territory posting costs go up (#1255322)

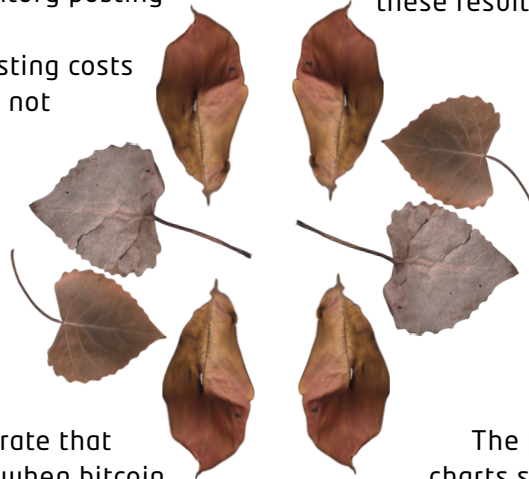
These results are identified from changes to territory posting costs and comparison of responses across territories. They are not driven by spurious correlations coming from global time trends or peculiarities about individual territories.

The next thing I wanted to ask is:

Does the fact that it's real money matter?

#1258001 was a failed attempt at addressing this question.

Today, I think I made some progress. I'm able to demonstrate that unprofitable users are more likely to become inactive when bitcoin price is high, compared to profitable users. This makes sense, because bitcoin price amplifies the losses of unprofitable users while simultaneously amplifying the gains of profitable ones.



Definitions

I define a user as "inactive" if they go for 4 or more weeks simultaneously without any posts, comments, or zaps. For each user who ever goes inactive, I document the week in which they started that spell of inactivity. We'll call that "becoming inactive."

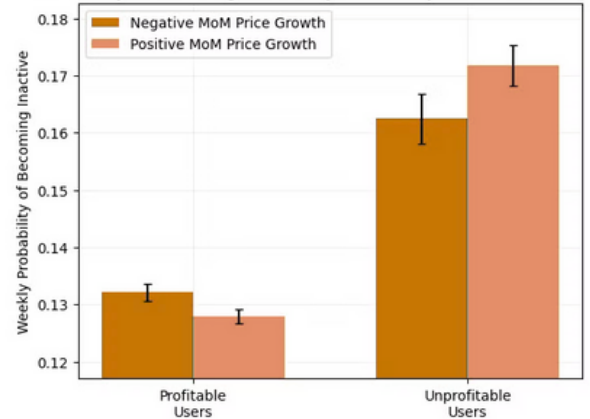
For each week in which a user is active, I also calculate their profitability from the last 8 weeks. Profit is measured using all sources of stacking as revenue (zaps, territory revenue, rewards, referrals), but only fees and territory billing as costs. I did not include zaps or donations as costs because those are optional choices by the users. They can be thought of more as how you choose to spend your profit, rather than as costs.

For each week, I also calculate the month-on-month bitcoin price appreciation measured between that week and a month ago; I also calculate how many items the user posted in the last 8 weeks as a measure of activity irrespective of profit.

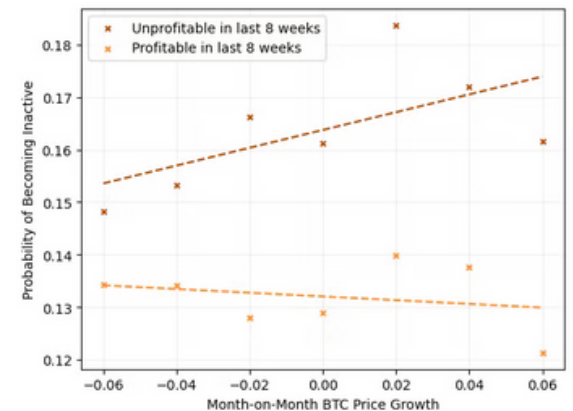
Results

I first present the results visually, then move to regression analysis to establish the statistical robustness of these results.

Probability of Becoming Inactive by Profitability and BTC Price Growth



* Profitability is defined as sats earned on zaps, rewards, referrals, and territory revenue minus any fees paid (including posting costs) and territory bills over the last 8 weeks. It does not subtract spending on zaps and donations.
** Inactivity is defined as a period of 4+ weeks without any posts, comments, or zapping.



The first two charts show that unprofitable users are more likely to become inactive.

c o n t i n u e d

This is not surprising at all. What's more interesting is that they are more likely to become inactive when bitcoin price has been appreciating. This may be because bitcoin price appreciation amplifies the real purchasing power of their losses. By contrast, profitable users are not more likely to become inactive when bitcoin price appreciates. On the contrary, they are slightly less likely to become inactive.

Next, I run regressions some regressions. The results are shown below.

Dependent variable:

	became_inactive			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Unprofitable last 8 weeks	0.901*** (0.024)	0.875*** (0.025)	0.391*** (0.027)	0.049*** (0.003)
MoM BTC price growth	-0.036 (0.084)	-0.197** (0.099)	-0.154 (0.099)	
Unprofitable X price growth		0.573*** (0.185)	0.512*** (0.190)	0.073*** (0.019)
log(Items) last 8 weeks			-0.432*** (0.008)	-0.029*** (0.001)
Constant		-2.498*** (0.014)	-2.492*** (0.014)	-1.507*** (0.021)

Model	Logit	Logit	Logit	LPM
Week FE	N	N	N	Y
Observations	100,278	100,278	100,278	100,278

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01



read further analysis and the author's conclusion

The only thing bitcoin is good at is breaking the law



4503 sats \ 33 comments \ @Scoresby 23 Oct bitcoin

What if Bitcoin is for criminals?

I have been listening to old episodes of Bitcoin Uncensored lately, and one of the things that Junseth repeatedly says is:

> *People will iterate Bitcoin up to the point it provides regulatory arbitrage and no further*

Unless I'm mistaken, he's saying that the main reason Bitcoin exists is to help people get around laws. We spend so much time defending ourselves against FUD like "Bitcoin is only used by criminals" and "It's just for money laundering" that we forget what it is that Bitcoin actually does: it eliminates the need for trusted third parties in the monetary system.

> *What is needed is an electronic payment system based on cryptographic proof instead of trust, allowing any two willing parties to transact directly with each other without the need for a trusted third party.*

Whitepaper



All this sounds nice and tame unless you really think about it. "Transact directly" means no one is in the way to stop you -- no one can stop you. That's the innovation of Bitcoin: every part of it is in service of this use-case.

Bitcoin is valuable because people want it. But why do people want it?

It is good, sometimes, to ask the question *"Why does anyone want bitcoin anyway?"*

The most common answer is probably because people want to make money. But that doesn't tell us much. Money isn't valuable just because it people say it's money. It's valuable because people want it. But why should people want it? What is it useful for?

Well, because there are only 21 million bitcoins. Nobody can make more bitcoin. Given the \$38 trillion dollar US national debt, this does seem like a useful quality; inflation sucks and central bank monetary policy often seems a little whimsical.

c o n t i n u e d

On the surface, I'm sure a government could promise to limit the supply of whatever currency they control...but they just never seem to be able to keep their promise.

And that's the problem: you have to take their word for it. Even if they aren't printing new dollars today, you don't have any way to know if they will print more dollars tomorrow.

But how do we know no one can change Bitcoin's 21 million supply cap?



It's in the code. The function that determines how the block reward halving works also sets the limit on Bitcoin's supply. Unchained has [a very nice explainer](#) if you want to learn more about it. But the



function is simple enough that even a non-developer like me can understand it. Even better, I can download a program, run it on my laptop, and type one command that will verify the total supply of bitcoin at that exact moment.

The code is pretty cool.

And how do we know the code won't change?

Bitcoin has had a number of forks, the consensus code has changed. What makes us so sure a government won't try to force their own change on the code (or that users won't decide to increase supply)?

Unlike any other money on Earth, you can verify the rules of Bitcoin (which is to say you can verify the consensus code) every time you receive a coin.

When someone offers to pay you Bitcoin and you use your own node to verify the transaction in which they send coins to you, you are enforcing the 21 million supply cap and all the other consensus rules of Bitcoin. You can choose to reject the payment if your node doesn't recognize it as following the rules.

So this is how we know the code won't change: it won't change as long as you won't change it.

But is that really why Bitcoin has value?

Running a program on your computer does not seem like it would be very valuable to anyone else.



***Proof of work
makes a program
running on one
computer
valuable to
other people***

Another one of the rules of Bitcoin is that when your node learns about a new block, it must check to see if this block's header has enough proof of work to meet the current network difficulty target.

This rule may seem like it's not relevant to anything else I've been saying, but it creates the wonderful property that as long as at least half the mining power in the world is not working together to censor you, you have a good chance of getting your transaction included in a block.

This is because anyone on Earth who has access to energy and mining equipment can attempt to mine the next block. The only rule is that they need to find a transaction header that will double hash to a number that meets the difficulty target. And if they do this, they get to pick the transactions that will go in their block and everyone else probably should accept that block and start building on top of it if they don't want to be left behind and waste their own hash power.

So if the existing miners refuse to mine certain kinds of transactions, the people who want to make those transactions can offer higher and higher fees until some miner decides to include them in a block.

And this is why Bitcoin is censorship resistant: because you can offer to pay anyone on earth to mine your transaction and anyone on earth can decide it is worth it to do so; and you can enforce this dynamic every time you accept bitcoin in trade by making sure that the coins you are accepting have been included in a block in the chain with the most weight. This is the great innovation of Bitcoin.



Bitcoin gives you the option to break the law

In a recent talk, Matt Corallo shared this thing his friend said:

> *Bitcoin simply doesn't work unless there's sufficient demand for censorship-resistant transactions in the world.*

If only a very few people want the option to break the law, if only a few people want censorship resistant money, it is unlikely this project works. This is because miners only get paid in bitcoin and that bitcoin is only valuable if people will accept it in trade and the only reason you might accept bitcoin instead of any other money is because it has this quality of being a peer to peer money with no trusted third parties -- which is to say, it is censorship resistant.

Satoshi came up with a system for aligning incentives so that we can route around people who try to censor transactions or control the rules of Bitcoin. All the rules of Bitcoin are dependent on this system -- if it doesn't work, all the other things we like about Bitcoin can trivially be altered.

So beware (or be less concerned about what the state will prohibit): Bitcoin is black market money and it is already illegal -- your government just hasn't realized it yet.